

2. Design Philosophy

This chapter is arguably the most important part of this document.

Many AI coding assistants tend to gradually redesign interfaces while implementing features. Small inconsistencies accumulate over time until the application loses its identity.

The purpose of this chapter is to prevent that.

Every UI decision should follow these principles.

Overall Design Direction

The project follows a modern minimalistic design language inspired by:

- Linear
- Notion
- Stripe
- Raycast
- Vercel
- Apple Human Interface Guidelines
- Swiss graphic design

The goal is **clarity**, not decoration.

The interface should feel professional, calm and trustworthy.

When a new user opens Peregri, they should immediately feel that the platform is reliable enough to trust strangers with expensive deliveries.

This is especially important because the platform deals with money and international shipping.

Design Keywords

Every screen should communicate:

Minimal.

Calm.

Precise.

Elegant.

Lightweight.

Trustworthy.

Professional.

International.

Never:

Playful.

Gaming.

Crypto.

Neon.

Over-designed.

Material Design 2014.

Visual Hierarchy

The interface should rely on spacing rather than borders.

Whitespace is an important design element.

Content should breathe.

Information should be grouped naturally instead of enclosed inside heavy containers.

Users should immediately understand:

- primary action
- secondary action
- supporting information

without excessive colors.

Simplicity over Decoration

Every decorative element should justify its existence.

Avoid:

- unnecessary gradients
- glowing effects
- oversized shadows
- animated backgrounds
- decorative illustrations
- floating shapes
- excessive icons

Minimalism is not the absence of design.

It is the removal of everything unnecessary.

Color Philosophy

Colors communicate function.

Not decoration.

The interface intentionally uses a restrained palette.

Most surfaces are neutral.

Accent colors are reserved for important interactions.

Examples:

- primary buttons
- selected states
- important links
- focused inputs

Avoid introducing random colors for individual components.

CSS Variables

The project uses CSS variables as the single source of truth.

Examples:

`--bg`

`--surface`

`--surface-hover`

`--border`

`--text`

`--text-secondary`

`--accent`

`--danger`

Components should never hardcode colors.

Instead they reference CSS variables.

Good:

`background: var(--bg);`

Bad:

`bg-slate-900`

`bg-gray-100`

`text-zinc-300`

These values may accidentally diverge from the design system.

Tailwind Philosophy

Tailwind is used as an implementation tool.

It is NOT the design system.

Tailwind utilities should consume project variables instead of inventing colors.

Correct:

`bg-[var(--bg)]`

`text-[var(--text)]`

Incorrect:

`bg-black`

`bg-slate-900`

`text-gray-500`

The design language belongs to Peregri, not Tailwind.

shadcn/ui Philosophy

shadcn/ui is used as a component foundation.

Its default appearance should not dictate the project's style.

Every component should be adjusted to match the Peregri design language.

If a default shadcn component conflicts with the design philosophy, customization is preferred over accepting the default.

Border Radius

Rounded corners should remain subtle.

The application intentionally avoids exaggerated rounding.

Preferred:

small radius

medium radius

Avoid:

rounded-2xl

rounded-3xl

pill-shaped cards

Cards should feel clean rather than playful.

Shadows

Shadows exist only to separate elevation levels.

Avoid heavy shadows.

The interface should not resemble floating glass objects.

Light shadows.

Soft shadows.

No dramatic effects.

Typography

Typography carries most of the visual hierarchy.

Instead of making everything colorful:

increase font weight.

adjust spacing.

modify size.

Good typography reduces the need for decoration.

Icons

Icons should support labels.

Not replace them.

Avoid interfaces that communicate entirely through icons.

Most important actions should remain understandable even if icons disappear.

Buttons

Buttons should have clear hierarchy.

Primary.

Secondary.

Ghost.

Danger.

Only one primary action should exist in each logical section.

Multiple competing primary buttons reduce clarity.

Forms

Forms should feel effortless.

Generous spacing.

Clear labels.

Helpful validation.

Minimal distractions.

Users should never wonder:

"What does this field mean?"

Mobile Philosophy

The application is mobile-first.

Most users will discover listings while traveling.

Every screen should feel natural on a phone before being optimized for desktop.

Desktop layouts should simply expand existing mobile layouts rather than becoming completely different interfaces.

Animations

Animations should support understanding.

Never entertainment.

Acceptable:

fade

small scale

smooth transitions

Avoid:

bounce

elastic movement

overshooting

large rotations

attention-grabbing motion

Users should barely notice animations.

But they should feel the interface is polished.

Empty States

Empty states should encourage action.

Not punish users.

Instead of:

"No listings found."

Prefer:

"No travelers match these filters yet.

Try expanding your search or creating your own request."

Always provide a next step.

Error Messages

Errors should explain:

What happened.

Why.

What to do next.

Avoid generic:

"Something went wrong."

Instead:

"We couldn't load available trips.

Please check your connection and try again."

Accessibility

Accessibility is considered from the beginning.

Requirements:

Proper semantic HTML.

Keyboard navigation.

Visible focus states.

Sufficient contrast.

Meaningful labels.

The goal is not merely passing automated tests.

The interface should genuinely be usable.

Consistency

Consistency is more valuable than novelty.

When implementing a new feature:

Prefer existing layouts.

Reuse existing components.

Reuse spacing.

Reuse typography.

Reuse colors.

The user should feel every page belongs to the same application.

AI Design Rules

Every AI agent contributing to the frontend must follow these rules:

- Never redesign existing pages unless explicitly instructed.
- Never replace CSS variables with Tailwind colors.
- Never introduce a second design language.

- Never increase border radius without approval.
- Prefer reusing components over creating similar ones.
- Preserve spacing consistency.
- Preserve typography hierarchy.
- Preserve minimalist philosophy.
- Match existing pages before inventing new styles.

The objective is for a user to never guess which page was built first or by whom.

Every screen should appear as if it was designed by the same person on the same day.